BORROWBOX

Campus Rental Business & MVP Launch Plan

Akwa Ibom, Nigeria | Founder-owned inventory pilot

THE CORE PROMISE
When a student urgently needs an item, BorrowBox helps them find and collect it from a nearby BorrowBox stock point, with clear pricing, verified payment and a recorded handover.

Prepared as a working founder blueprint • 9 November 2026

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1. Executive summary

BorrowBox is a campus-focused, on-demand rental service for academic essentials, equipment and useful student items. The initial launch will use inventory purchased and controlled by the two founders. Students will book directly from BorrowBox, pay through the platform and collect from designated campus-area locations. This is deliberately different from launching as a peer-to-peer marketplace on day one.

The first objective is to prove that students will repeatedly pay for short-term access to items they need urgently or occasionally. The first version should prioritize reliable inventory, fast matching, secure payment confirmation, safe collection and return, and accurate stock records.

STRATEGIC RECOMMENDATIONStart as a managed-inventory rental operator with a digital booking system. Add third-party student and vendor listings only after the founders have proven the rental workflow and built trust.

2. Business model and launch phases

Phase 1 — Founder-owned inventory

- The founders purchase a carefully selected set of items.
- BorrowBox lists only items physically in stock and available for the selected location and time.
- Students book and pay BorrowBox directly.
- BorrowBox staff or an authorized attendant verifies the booking and hands over the item.
- BorrowBox receives the item back, inspects it, updates stock and processes any eligible deposit refund.

Phase 2 — Multiple BorrowBox stock points

- Add additional collection points only when demand and operations justify them.
- Assign each item a unique asset code and a specific home location.
- Use location-level stock counts and transfers between stock points.

Phase 3 — Hybrid marketplace

- Allow approved students, graduates, equipment owners and campus businesses to list their own items.
- Add owner verification, listing moderation, third-party payout workflows and stronger dispute handling.
- Do not treat third-party payouts as ordinary founder-owned inventory revenue; use a reviewed marketplace settlement design.

3. Target customers and use cases

Customer need	Example	Rental pattern
Urgent forgotten item	Lab coat, calculator, drawing instrument	Immediate / same day
Short academic requirement	Textbook, drawing board, project tool	Hours / days / weeks
Practical or project work	Multimeter, mechanical tool, electronics kit	Scheduled short-term
Presentation or content work	Projector, microphone, camera accessory	Hours / days
Temporary technology access	Laptop, monitor or accessory	Days / weeks

Important: some schools, departments and laboratories may require personally issued or institution-approved protective equipment. BorrowBox must not encourage students to bypass laboratory, examination, safety or departmental rules. Verify the acceptability of each category with the relevant institution before stocking it.

4. Inventory strategy

Do not buy a broad range of expensive stock before measuring demand. Start with a narrow set of portable, durable, easy-to-inspect items that solve frequent student problems. Avoid high-value laptops, cameras and specialized lab equipment until the team has reliable verification, insurance/risk arrangements where appropriate, and proven controls.

Potential starting category	Examples	Launch decision
Academic essentials	Scientific calculators, selected textbooks, drawing instruments	Test demand and institution rules first
Practical equipment	Basic multimeters, approved tools, breadboards	Start with low-risk, inspectable items
Presentation equipment	Tripods, microphones, small projectors	Add after validating booking demand
Protective clothing	Lab coats and similar items	Only with hygiene, sizing and institution-acceptance controls
High-value technology	Laptops, cameras, monitors	Defer until controls and economics are proven

Inventory controls

- Give every physical item a unique asset ID, barcode or QR code.
- Record purchase cost, serial/model number, condition, photos, accessories and home stock point.
- Record every reservation, collection, return, maintenance event, loss and write-off.
- Set buffer time between bookings for inspection, cleaning, charging and maintenance.
- Never show an item as available if it is already booked, under repair, missing or awaiting inspection.
- Review utilization, revenue per asset, damage, downtime and payback period before buying more stock.

5. User verification and account controls

5.1 Account verification

- Collect the minimum information needed: legal name, phone, email, university and relevant student details.
- Verify phone ownership using a one-time passcode; verify email where practical.
- Use secure authentication, rate limits and account recovery controls.

5.2 Student status verification

- For the pilot, use manual review of a current student ID or another institution-accepted proof of current student status.
- Check that the name and institution match the account; record verification status and reviewer, not unnecessary copies of documents.
- If a document image must temporarily be collected, restrict staff access, protect it, define a short retention period and delete it when no longer needed.
- Do not collect NIN or biometric information by default. Only introduce stronger identity checks if a documented risk assessment and lawful basis justify them.

5.3 Rental-level verification

– The user selects an item, rental period and collection location.

– The backend checks current availability and calculates all charges.

– The user accepts the rental terms, due time, deposit and return rules before payment.

– Payment is verified server-to-server before the booking becomes eligible for collection.

– At collection, an attendant checks the booking QR/OTP and matches the person to the verified account/student profile.

– The attendant records the item condition, accessories and handover time; both sides confirm handover.

– At return, the attendant checks the same asset ID, condition and accessories, records evidence where needed and closes the booking.

VERIFICATION PRINCIPLEA verified student account does not prove that a particular rental has been paid for or that an item has been handed over. Account verification, payment verification and physical handover confirmation must be separate checks.

6. Payment design

For the founder-owned inventory pilot, BorrowBox is the supplier and payee. The first version does not need peer-to-peer split settlement. Use a business payment account in the appropriate business name and keep complete transaction records.

6.1 Separate the charges

Charge	Purpose	Treatment
Rental fee	Payment for use of the item for the agreed period	Recognize as rental revenue under the business's accounting policy
Refundable security deposit	Security against defined non-return or damage risks	Track as a refundable liability; do not treat as earned revenue
Approved additional charge	A justified late, missing-accessory or damage charge under agreed terms	Document evidence, calculation and customer communication

6.2 Illustrative checkout

Line item	Illustrative amount
Rental fee	■1,000
Refundable deposit	■5,000
Total due before collection	■6,000

If the item is returned in the agreed condition and on time, BorrowBox retains the rental fee and refunds the deposit. These numbers are examples only; actual prices and deposits must be tested against student willingness to pay and item replacement cost.

6.3 Recommended payment flow

– Create a pending booking with a unique booking ID and a short payment-expiry time.

– Calculate rental fee, deposit, discounts and any disclosed service fee on the server, not from client-supplied totals.

– Initialize payment with the provider from the backend; never expose secret API keys in frontend code.

– Receive the provider's webhook and validate its signature using the raw request body.

– Verify the transaction reference with the provider's server API; check success status, expected amount, currency, reference and booking association.

– Make payment processing idempotent so duplicate webhooks cannot create duplicate paid bookings.

– Only after confirmed payment, mark the booking paid and issue a collection QR/OTP.

– At return, close the booking and initiate the deposit refund through the provider's supported refund flow or an appropriately controlled bank transfer process.

– Reconcile provider transactions, bank settlements, rental revenue and refundable deposit balances daily.

DO NOT RELEASE ON A SCREENSHOTA payment screenshot, browser redirect or client-side success message is not proof of payment. The backend must confirm the provider's transaction status before staff hands over an item.

6.4 Deposit policy

• Display the exact deposit amount and refund conditions before payment.

• Set deposits proportionately to the item, its replacement value, risk and rental duration; avoid deposits that make low-cost items inaccessible.

• Keep a deposit ledger by booking and customer. Reconcile outstanding refundable deposits regularly.

• Publish a clear refund timeline and payment method. Explain that bank/provider processing may affect the final arrival time.

• Do not automatically forfeit the whole deposit for a minor issue. Any deduction should be based on disclosed terms, evidence and a reasonable calculation.

• For disputes, preserve the evidence and pause disputed deductions until reviewed.

6.5 Payment provider recommendation

Paystack is a reasonable provider to evaluate for the first Nigerian pilot. Its documentation describes transaction initialization, server-side verification, webhooks, refunds and transfer workflows. Confirm current eligibility, fees, settlement timing, supported refund behavior, business onboarding requirements and whether the proposed deposit handling is acceptable under the provider's current terms before going live.

Do not describe the deposit process as escrow unless a properly authorized escrow arrangement actually exists. Paystack split payments are settlement-splitting tools, not proof that funds are held in escrow. Since the founders own the stock, split payments are unnecessary for the initial model.

7. Collection, handover and return operations

7.1 Collection points

• Use approved, visible, safe campus-area locations with permission where required.

• Assign an attendant or named founder to each active collection point.

• Publish operating hours, directions, contact channel and what identification is required.

• Avoid random meetups, private residences and unsafe late-night exchanges during the pilot.

7.2 Handover checklist

• Scan booking QR or enter one-time collection code.

• Confirm booking is paid, active, not cancelled and assigned to that location.

• Match the collecting person to the verified account.

- Inspect the item with the renter; record visible condition and included accessories.
- Capture timestamp and confirmation from the attendant and renter.
- Change inventory status to RENTED and record expected return time.

7.3 Return checklist

- Scan the asset and booking ID.
- Check identity/account and expected return.
- Inspect condition and accessories against the handover record.
- Record normal wear separately from damage or missing components.
- If disputed, record the facts and route the case to an authorized reviewer.
- Close the rental, update inventory status and initiate eligible deposit refund.

7.4 Overdue items

- Send reminders before and at the due time.
- Offer an extension only if the item is not already reserved and the extension is paid/confirmed.
- Use a clear, proportionate late-fee policy disclosed before booking.
- Escalate repeated non-return through a documented customer-support and lawful recovery process; do not threaten, shame or unlawfully retain unrelated property.

8. Pricing and unit economics

Set prices by item, rental duration and demand. The team should test hourly, daily and weekly options where operationally sensible. A low rental price is not automatically profitable: include payment charges, cleaning, maintenance, staff time, damage, downtime and asset depreciation.

Metric	How to calculate
Rental revenue per booking	Rental fee actually earned, excluding refundable deposit
Contribution per booking	Rental revenue minus variable payment, handling, cleaning and maintenance costs
Utilization	Time rented ÷ time available for rental
Revenue per asset	Rental revenue generated by one asset over a chosen period
Payback period	Asset purchase cost ÷ average monthly contribution from that asset
Damage/loss rate	Number or cost of damaged/lost assets ÷ rentals or asset-days

Do not use security deposits as sales revenue in projections. Model refunds and losses separately. Prepare conservative, base and optimistic scenarios only after collecting actual pilot data.

9. MVP product scope

Module	MVP requirements
Customer account	Registration, login, phone/email verification, student verification status, profile
Catalogue	Categories, item photos, condition, location, price, duration options, availability
Request/search	Search available stock; request an item if no suitable listing is available
Booking	Date/time selection, price calculation, deposit disclosure, terms acceptance, booking status
Payments	Provider checkout, server verification, webhook handling, refund records, receipts
Collection/return	QR/OTP, staff confirmation, timestamp, condition checklist, return inspection
Customer dashboard	Active rentals, due time, booking history, receipts, support
Admin operations	Inventory, stock locations, bookings, payments, deposits, overdue items, disputes, users, audit log
Notifications	Booking confirmation, collection instructions, due reminders, return and refund updates

9.1 Suggested technical stack

- Frontend: React + TypeScript.
- Backend: Node.js + TypeScript with a well-defined API.
- Database: PostgreSQL; Prisma or Drizzle are reasonable options.
- Hosting: a frontend host such as Vercel plus a backend/database arrangement appropriate for reliable webhooks.
- Payments: Paystack or another approved provider after onboarding and fee review.
- Images: controlled object storage with access rules.
- Security: role-based access, server-side validation, rate limits, secure secrets, backups and audit logs.

The database should include users, student_verifications, locations, assets, asset_images, asset_status_history, bookings, booking_items, payments, deposits, refunds, handovers, returns, damage_reports, notifications, support_cases and audit_logs. Use database transactions and constraints to prevent overlapping bookings and duplicate payment fulfillment.

10. Privacy, safety and consumer protection

- Publish a privacy notice explaining what data is collected, why, who can access it, how long it is retained and how users can exercise their rights.
- Collect the minimum personal data necessary. Avoid collecting NIN, biometrics or contact lists by default.
- Restrict student-document access to designated verifiers; do not expose identity documents to other users or ordinary attendants.
- Use encrypted connections, secure storage, role-based permissions and audit logs.
- Publish clear rental terms, item condition, full price, deposit, due time, cancellation, refund, late return and damage policies before checkout.
- Provide receipts and a support/dispute channel.
- Have a Nigerian lawyer review the business structure, partnership agreement, rental terms, liability, insurance needs, privacy notice and payment/deposit treatment before launch.

Relevant legal frameworks to review include the Nigeria Data Protection Act 2023 and the Federal Competition and Consumer Protection Act 2018. This document is operational planning guidance, not legal advice or a compliance certification.

11. Founder roles and governance

Responsibility	Founder A	Founder B
Product, software and payment integration	Lead / accountable	Review and approve business requirements
Inventory sourcing and asset records	Joint approval	Lead / accountable
Collection point operations	Assigned location	Assigned location
Customer support and disputes	Shared rota	Shared rota
Cash, settlement and deposit reconciliation	Dual review	Dual review
Purchases and pricing changes	Agree in writing	Agree in writing

Before purchasing stock, agree in writing who owns each asset, how much each founder contributed, how losses are handled, who can authorize refunds, how profits are calculated, how expenses are approved and what happens if one founder leaves. Do not rely on informal verbal assumptions.

12. Pilot rollout plan

Stage	Work	Exit condition
1. Campus discovery	Choose first institution and target area; interview students; check campus rules; identify collection points	Evidence of urgent needs and permission/feasibility for operations
2. Inventory test	Get supplier quotes; test willingness to pay; choose a small initial stock list	Unit economics and demand assumptions documented
3. Manual pilot	Use a simple catalogue, payment links/provider checkout and controlled booking register	First completed, paid, returned rentals with reconciled deposits
4. MVP build	Automate catalogue, availability, booking, payment confirmation, handover and return	End-to-end tests pass, including failures and refunds
5. Controlled launch	Launch to a limited student group and a small number of stock points	Reliable fulfillment, acceptable contribution margin and manageable support load
6. Expansion decision	Review demand, utilization, loss/damage, repeat usage and location economics	Evidence supports adding stock, a new location or marketplace suppliers

12.1 Suggested first 30 days

– Week 1: Select the first university and exact pilot area; interview at least 20 potential renters and 10 potential inventory users/owners; verify institutional and collection-point rules.

– Week 2: Compare supplier prices, choose a narrow initial stock list, set trial prices/deposits and write customer terms.

– Week 3: Run a controlled manual pilot. Record every inquiry, booking, payment, collection, return, refund and issue.

– Week 4: Review the data. Decide what to buy next and which software steps are worth automating.

The interview counts above are proposed validation targets, not completed research or evidence of demand.

13. Pilot metrics and weekly founder review

Metric	Why it matters
Requests received by item/category	Shows what students ask for
Request-to-booking conversion	Measures whether supply and price meet demand
Time from request to confirmed availability	Measures speed of fulfillment
Paid bookings and completed returns	Proves real transactions, not just interest
Repeat customer rate	Indicates ongoing usefulness
Utilization by asset and location	Shows whether stock is earning its keep
Contribution per rental	Shows whether each transaction is economically worthwhile
Late, damaged, missing and disputed items	Measures operational and fraud exposure
Deposit refund time and outstanding deposits	Protects customer trust and cash controls
Customer complaints and satisfaction	Shows where the service is failing

Weekly review should separate verified numbers from estimates. Do not call registrations, likes, survey interest or unconfirmed requests revenue or product-market fit.

14. Main risks and mitigations

Risk	Initial control
Buying stock students do not rent	Interview, pre-test demand and start with limited quantities
Theft or non-return	Student verification, deposit, handover record, clear terms and proportionate escalation
Damage disputes	Timestamped condition records, accessories checklist and review process
Payment spoofing	Server-side verification, signed webhooks and idempotent processing
Double booking	Database constraints and atomic reservation logic
Stock mismatch between locations	Asset IDs, location ledger and regular physical counts
Poor refund experience	Refund policy, daily reconciliation and status notifications
Founder disagreement	Written founders' agreement and dual approval for major decisions
Unsafe or unauthorized equipment use	Category-specific safety and institutional checks

15. Decisions required before launch

- Confirm the first university and specific pilot zone in Akwa Ibom.
- Confirm the legal/business structure and founders' ownership agreement.
- Agree the first stock list and maximum capital at risk.
- Confirm campus permissions and collection-point arrangements.
- Approve rental, deposit, cancellation, damage and refund policies after legal review.
- Complete payment-provider onboarding and test payment/refund flows.
- Define who can verify students, release stock, approve refunds and resolve disputes.

• Run a manual pilot before committing to a full application build.

16. Official references and implementation reading

• Paystack — Verify Payments — Server-side transaction verification and transaction status.
https://paystack.com/docs/payments/verify-payments/

• Paystack — Webhooks — Webhook signature verification and event handling.
https://paystack.com/docs/payments/webhooks/

• Paystack — Refunds — Review current refund API behavior and requirements before implementation.
https://paystack.com/docs/payments/refunds/

• Paystack — Split Payments — Potential future marketplace settlement model; not escrow.
https://paystack.com/docs/payments/split-payments/

• Nigeria Data Protection Act 2023 (NDPC) — Personal-data processing obligations.
https://ndpc.gov.ng/wp-content/uploads/2024/03/Nigeria_Data_Protection_Act_2023.pdf

• FCCPC — Consumer rights and responsibilities — Consumer information, bookings and refund considerations.
https://fccpc.gov.ng/consumers/consumer-rights-responsibilities/rights-responsibilities/

17. Final founder recommendation

BorrowBox should earn trust through operational reliability before trying to become a large marketplace. The founders' initial inventory model is a practical way to control quality and prove the complete rental loop. Start small, record every transaction, protect customer deposits, keep stock accurate and expand only when the numbers justify it. The first success metric is not app downloads; it is a student paying, collecting an item, returning it and choosing BorrowBox again.

NORTH STARA student can find a suitable item, understand the full cost, pay securely, collect it at a known location and return it without confusion or unfair treatment.